

Figure 1. Australian Islamic Centre by Glenn Murcutt + Elevli Plus (author: Pintos; source: Archdaily)

Explore the relationship between Glenn Murcutt's design philosophy and Islamic design in the Australian Islamic Centre in Newport.

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World renowned Australian architect, Glenn Murcutt has continued to push the bounds of his own creativity with the Australian Islamic Centre project in Newport, in the western suburbs of Melbourne. While Murcutt is credited with “primarily designing environmentally sensitive, energy conscious, modernist houses that respond to their surroundings and climate” (The architect down under. (Industry), 2002), with this project he has seemingly stepped out of his comfort zone of residential homes to design a memorable public space for prayer and contemplation which is in harmony with its surrounds. Combining his design philosophy with historical, and reinterpreted, Islamic design was challenging but has proven to be revolutionary for the Australian suburban environment.

On recognising his deficiencies regarding intimate knowledge of Islamic architecture and culture, he worked in conjunction with architect Hakan Elevli. Elevli explains that the local community described their hopes for the new mosque as: "We want to design the first true Australian mosque for non Muslims, for new Australian Muslims." (Edgar, R. (2016). The design brief itself “was for a modern and Australian building that would contribute to a positive interpretation of the mosque as a welcome architectural feature of suburban Australia.” (Pintos, P. (2019).

Being new to the world of Islamic architecture enabled Murcutt to question existing methodologies and to view the design in a new way. The result was to incorporate his modernist style, his love for light and cross ventilation, and to design for, and maximise, the local climate.

The primary materials of the mosque are concrete and glass. Its four walls consist of three concrete walls and the eastern wall is glass. Historically, a minaret would be the welcome for visitors, however, in this modern design, the elegant sculptural south concrete wall extends outward to the street providing a welcoming beacon that encourages visitors inside. Domes and arches are regularly featured in mosque architecture, however here the dome has been replaced with rooftop coloured lanterns which provide natural light to the main prayer hall. Cross-ventilation is provided with the installation of louvres to the exterior of the rooftop lanterns.

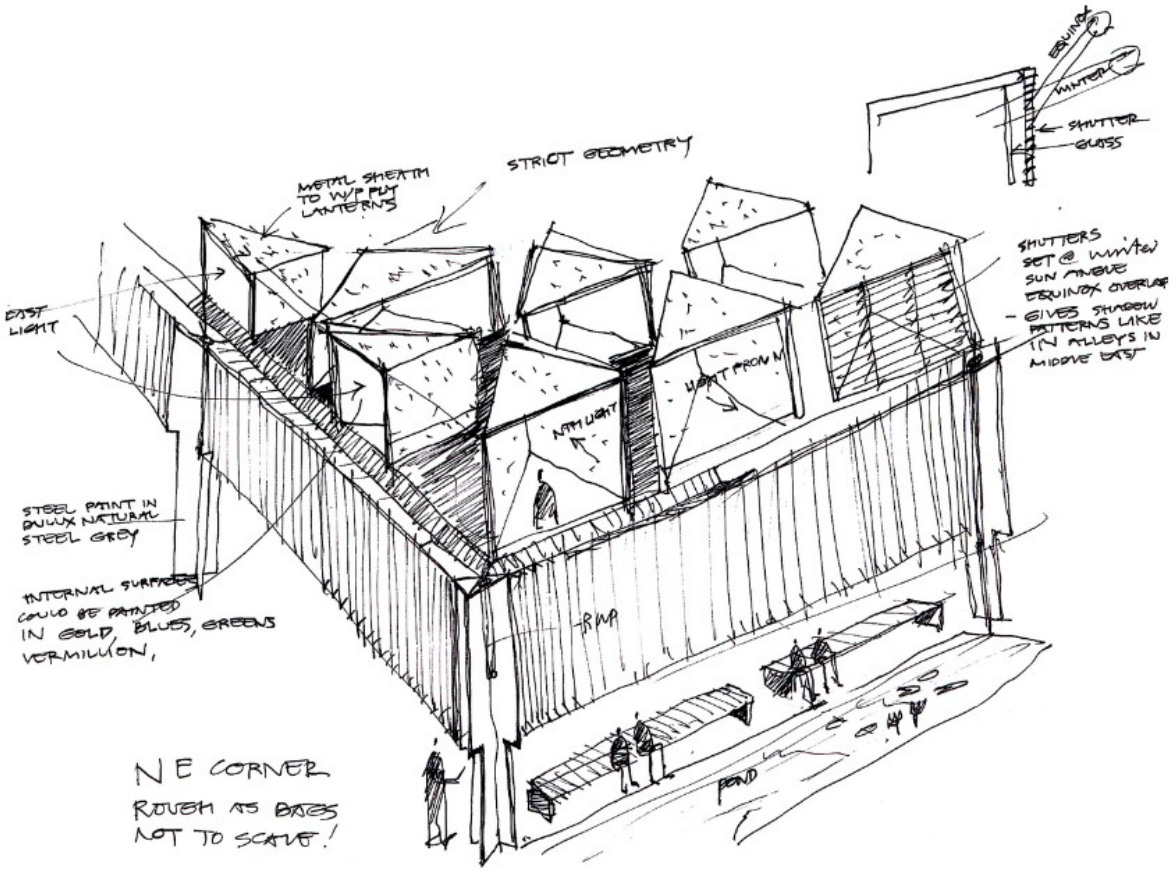


Figure 2. Australian Islamic Centre by Glenn Murcutt + Elevli Plus (author: Pintos; source: Archdaily)

The mosque features many of the fundamental traits of Islamic design, including facing the direction of Mecca, separate areas for men and women, and pools of still water. The roof of the mosque has an innovative feature - “triangular lanterns admit light, its colour varied by orientation: gold glazing oriented to the east, green to the north, red to the west, blue to the south." (Walker, P. (2019). The light flows seamlessly into the prayer hall providing a continuous patchwork of shapes and a changing colour palette throughout the day, dependent on the path of the sun. The colours chosen are deliberate and symbolic, while the patterning imitates that of historical tessellated tiles. According to the positioning of the glazing and the sun path, in the morning a sea of yellow shapes are cast onto the floor of the hall, changing to blue and green around midday, and becoming red in the afternoon. Another considered feature of the design are the eye-catching inscriptions that have been cast and carefully positioned in the concrete walls. Viewed from the internal spaces, these are an artistic, symbolic and deeply meaningful attribute of the structure which has been reinterpreted for today.



Figure 3. Australian Islamic Centre by Glenn Murcutt + Elevli Plus (author: Pintos; source: Archdaily)

Building the same structures over and over and never being inspired to explore new ideas would be the death of architecture. The Glenn Murcutts of the world, who believe in a thoughtful and considered approach to each build, embracing innovation, and designing for the physical and cultural environment, ensure that architecture will never stay the same and will never be boring. Instead, modern design in the hands of the creative can be a celebration of what is possible. What is possible with varying requirements, varying site conditions, varying materials. A celebration of diversity - how exciting and inspiring for designers of, and admirers of, the built environment.

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